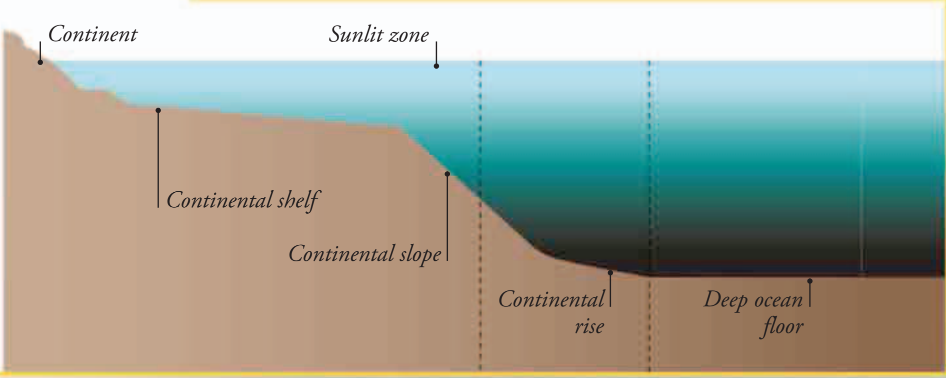
SUNLIT SEAS

The ocean sunlit zone is confined to the top 660 ft (200 m). Since continental shelf seas average 490 ft (150 m) deep, their entire depth lies within the sunlit zone—the region where most marine animals live. In the deep oceans, most of the water is too dark to support the organisms that need the energy of light to make food, so fewer animals can live there.



Fertile waters

Shallow coastal seas are much richer in marine life than the deep oceans. This is partly because the water contains more of the nutrients needed by the tiny plantlike organisms that drift in the water, called phytoplankton. Light also filters all the way down through the shallow water to the seabed, fueling the growth of phytoplankton and providing food for animal life at all depths.

WOW!

Just seven percent of the total ocean area is made up of shallow shelf seas, but most of the world's marine life lives in them.

MINERAL RICHES

Plantlike seaweeds and phytoplankton do not only need light. They need mineral nutrients that they can turn into living tissue—the basic food source for all other marine life. In coastal seas, rivers flowing off the land deliver plenty of these mineral nutrients. Other vital minerals are dissolved from coastal rocks by the waves.

◀ VITAL MINERALS
A satellite view of the mouth of China's Yellow River shows how minerals carried by the river turn the sea itself yellow.